- The torque experienced by the Earth due to the gravitational force of the Sun is given by

$$\vec{\tau} = \vec{r} \times \vec{F} = \vec{r} \times \left(-\frac{GM_S M_E}{r^2} \hat{r} \right) = 0$$

Since $\vec{r} = r\,\hat{r}$, $(\hat{r} \times \hat{r}) = 0$

So $\vec{\tau} = \frac{d\vec{L}}{dt} = 0$. It implies that angular momentum $\vec{L}$ is a constant vector. The angular momentum of the Earth about the Sun is constant throughout the motion. It is true for all the planets. In fact, this constancy of angular momentum leads to the Kepler's second law.

- The expression $\vec{F} = -\frac{GM_1 M_2}{r^2} \hat{r}$ has one inherent assumption that both M_1 and M_2 are treated as point masses. When it is said that Earth orbits around the Sun due to Sun's gravitational force, we assumed Earth and Sun to be point masses. This assumption is a good approximation because the distance between the two bodies is very much larger than their diameters. For some irregular and extended objects separated by a small distance, we cannot directly use the equation (6.3). Instead, we have to invoke separate mathematical treatment which will be brought forth in higher classes.
- However, this assumption about point masses holds even for small distance for one special case. To calculate force of attraction between a hollow sphere of mass M with uniform density and point mass m kept outside the hollow sphere, we can replace the hollow sphere of mass M as equivalent to a point mass M located at the center of the hollow sphere. The force of attraction between the hollow sphere of mass M and point mass m can be calculated by treating the hollow sphere also as another point mass. Essentially the entire mass of the hollow sphere appears to be concentrated at the center of the hollow sphere. It is shown in the Figure 6.5(a).
- There is also another interesting result. Consider a hollow sphere of mass M. If we place another object of mass 'm' inside this hollow sphere as in Figure 6.5(b), the force experienced by this mass 'm' will be zero. This calculation will be dealt with in higher classes.

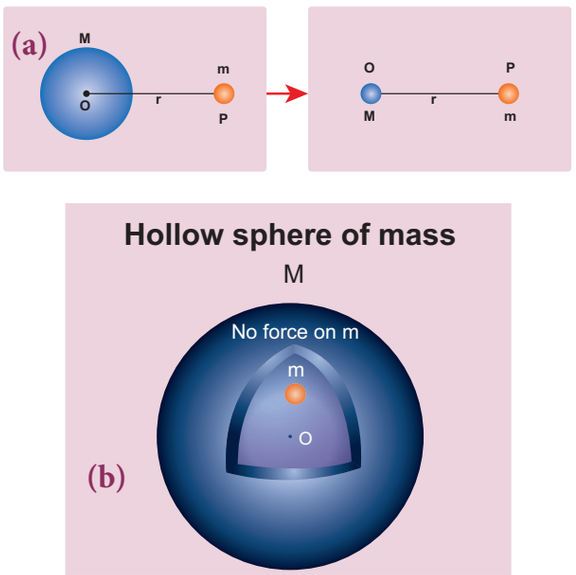


Figure 6.5 A mass placed in a hollow sphere.

- The triumph of the law of gravitation is that it concludes that the mango that is falling down and the Moon orbiting the Earth are due to the same gravitational force.

Newton's inverse square Law:

Newton considered the orbits of the planets as circular. For circular orbit of radius r, the centripetal acceleration towards the center is

$$a = -\frac{v^2}{r} \qquad (6.4)$$

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